



NODUS · COMPLETE VAULT GUIDE

Genealogy

Reconstruct people, families and events without losing the documentary trail.

The Genealogy vault connects a family tree to people, life events, places, social relations, archival records and research notes. Every relationship can be reviewed against evidence.

EDITION	English
VERSION	Nodus 4.1
UPDATED	14 August 2026
AUDIENCE	Family historians, genealogists and local-history researchers.

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PART I · FOUNDATION

Core Nodus workflow

These operating principles apply to every vault. They establish the local-first data boundary, source workflow, optional model configuration and recovery discipline used throughout this manual.

START HERE

1 Welcome to Nodus

Nodus is a local-first desktop workspace for research, teaching and study. Work is organised into focused vaults that share one private engine.

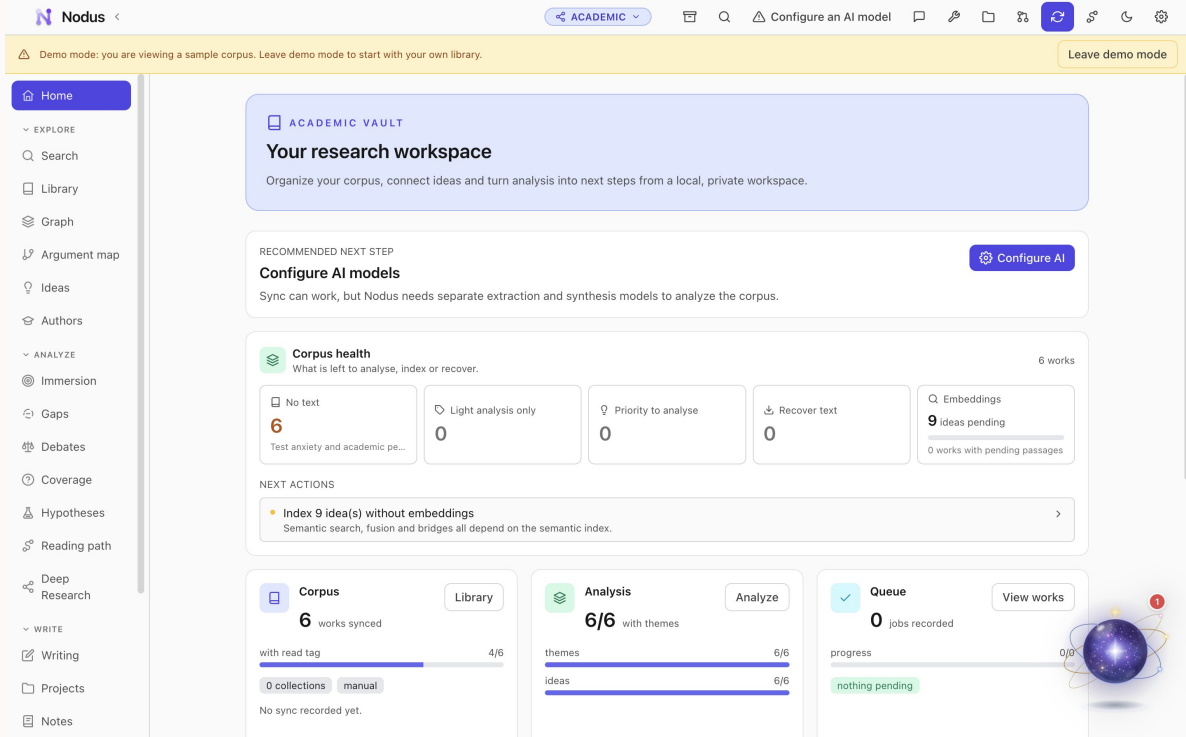
A vault changes the navigation, workflows and assistant context without changing the core promises: your database and indexes remain on your computer, accounts are optional, and AI runs only when a feature needs it and you have configured a provider.

STEP BY STEP

1. Install the current package for macOS, Windows or Linux from the Nodus release page.
2. Open Nodus and choose the interface language, Nodi style and tutorial path.
3. Create a vault for the kind of work you are doing, or load its sample vault before importing your own material.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use one vault per coherent project, course, family or dataset.
- Sample vaults are disposable and are the safest way to explore.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

START HERE

2 Create and switch vaults

Create independent workspaces and move between them without mixing their context.

The vault switcher is the boundary between projects. Each vault has its own notes, analysis and domain records, while the global Library can link the same source into compatible vaults without duplicating it.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open the vault switcher from the application header and choose New vault.
2. Name the vault, choose its type and review the short description before confirming.
3. Use the same switcher to move to another vault; Nodus restores the last open section.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use explicit names such as 'MA thesis - memory' or 'Biology 2026'.
- Changing a vault type after substantial work is not a substitute for creating the correct vault.

ESSENTIALS

3 Navigation and global search

The sidebar exposes the workflow for the active vault; search retrieves material across the relevant local index.

Sections are grouped by intent - explore, analyse and write, or organisation and assessment. Search combines exact keyword matching with semantic retrieval when an embedding model is configured, and results preserve links to their source.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a section in the left sidebar; the active section is highlighted.
2. Open Search and enter at least two meaningful characters or a natural-language concept.
3. Filter or inspect a result, then follow its source link to the document, record, person or note.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Search for concepts, not only exact titles.
- Rebuild an index from Settings if recently imported content does not appear.

ESSENTIALS

4 Library, sources and reader

Keep preserved originals beside clean reading copies, citations, highlights and extracted evidence.

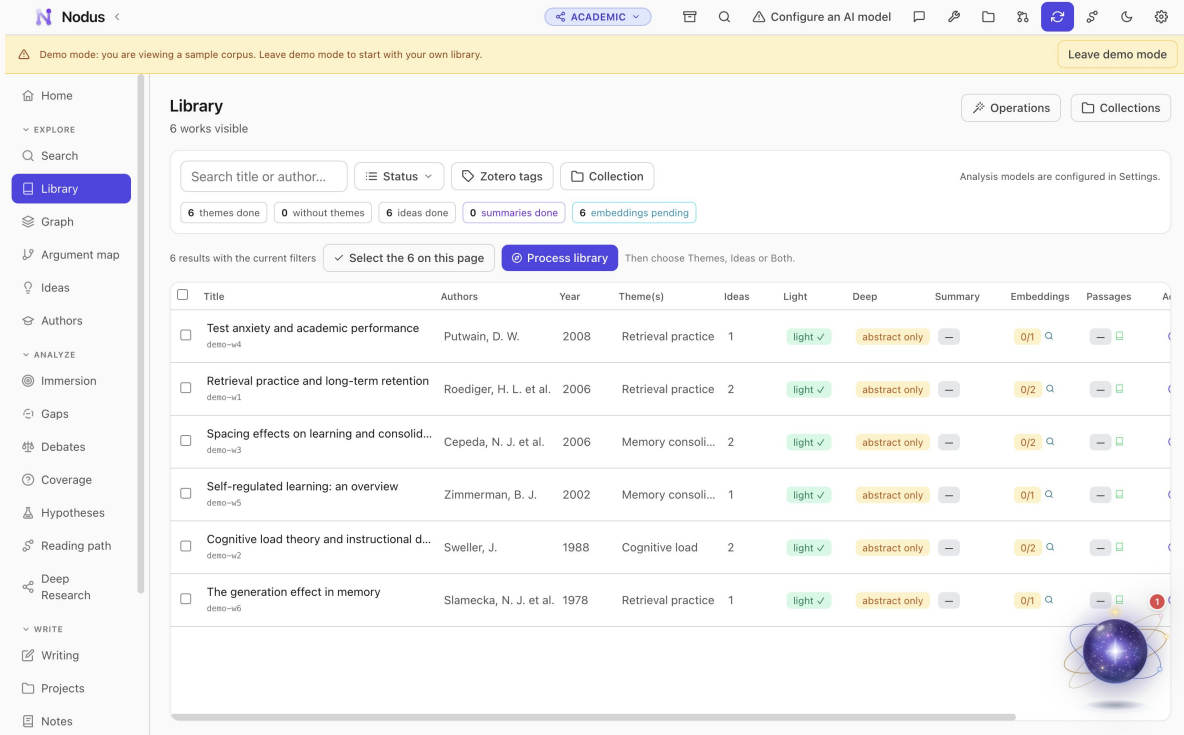
The cross-vault Library can mirror Zotero, import RIS, BibTeX and CSL JSON, or accept files directly. Nodus preserves the original attachment and creates searchable derivatives. Compatible sources can be linked to several vaults without copying the original.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Library and add a local file, import bibliographic data or connect Zotero.
2. Place the item in a collection and add useful tags; wait for extraction and indexing to finish.
3. Open the item, choose the clean reading copy or preserved original, then highlight passages and link the item into the active vault.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the preserved original for page-accurate verification.
- Treat automatically extracted text and metadata as a first pass that may need correction.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

CONFIGURATION

5 AI providers and task models

Bring your own cloud key or use compatible local models, with a different model for each task.

Provider keys are stored in the operating-system keychain. Nodus distinguishes deterministic local tools from model-assisted features and shows when content will leave the device. Model preferences can mix providers by extraction, chat, writing and report tasks.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, then Providers, and configure a cloud key or local endpoint.
2. Use the validation action before saving, then open Models.
3. Assign a suitable model to each task and run a small test on sample content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A local model improves privacy but may require more memory and time.
- Review every generated claim against its linked evidence.

CONFIGURATION

6 Privacy, backups and recovery

Protect local work with a verified backup and understand exactly when network services are used.

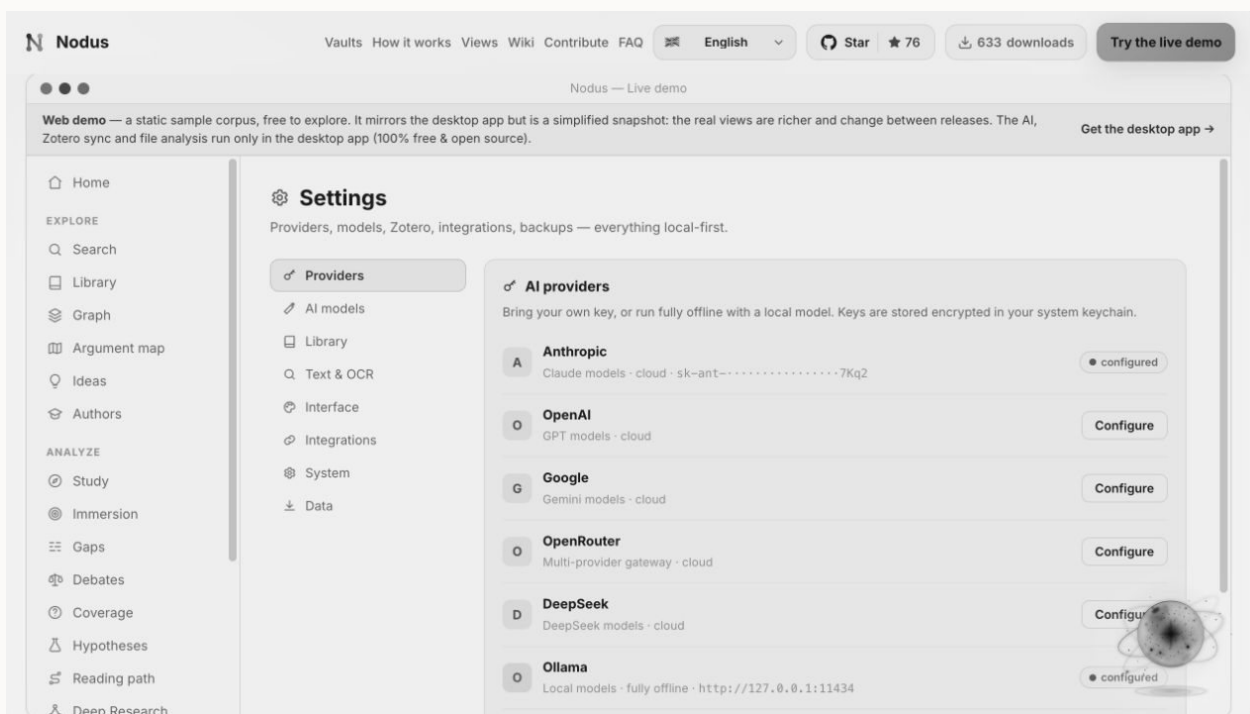
Vault databases, indexes and library files are local by default. Backups can include all vaults and the shared Library. Nodus reports backup health and creates protected recovery copies before major migrations.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, choose a backup destination and enable automatic backups.
2. Run a manual backup, then use verification to confirm that its manifest and files are readable.
3. Review the privacy notice for each optional online feature before sending content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Store backups on a different physical device or a trusted encrypted location.
- Do not treat sync as a backup; keep versioned recovery copies.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

CONFIGURATION

7 Toolkit and integrations

Convert, protect, translate, OCR and present documents, or connect Zotero, Word, MCP clients and Nodus Server.

Toolkit utilities are available across vaults. Integrations remain optional: Zotero supplies bibliographic material, Word uses grounded Nodus context, MCP exposes approved local tools, and Nodus Server publishes a selected copy rather than the source vault.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Toolkit and choose Convert, Protect, Translate, OCR Workspace or PDF Presenter.
2. Select a file from disk or a compatible vault source and review the output options.
3. For an integration, enable only the connector you need and test it with non-sensitive sample content first.

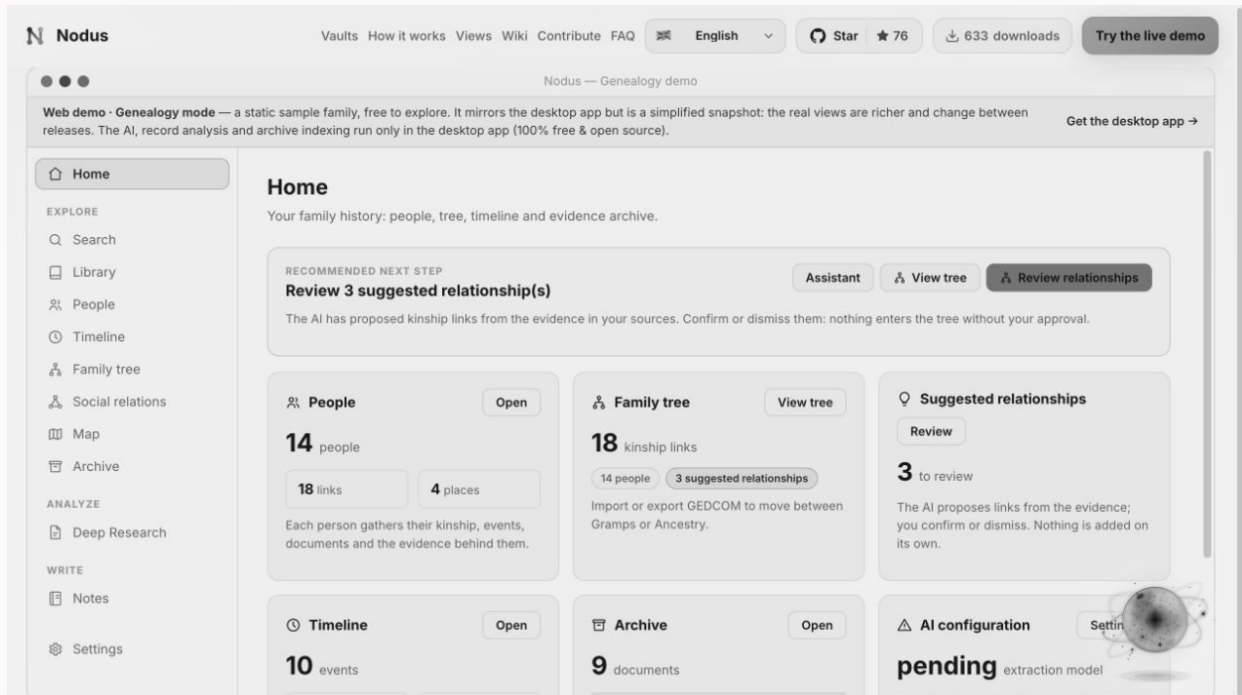
GOOD PRACTICE

- Permanent redaction in Protect is local and irreversible in the exported copy.
- Published server spaces should contain only material intended for their readers.

PART II · VAULT GUIDE

Complete Genealogy workflow

The Genealogy vault connects a family tree to people, life events, places, social relations, archival records and research notes. Every relationship can be reviewed against evidence.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

ORIENTATION

1 Home and research status

See people, relationships, events, records and suggestions at a glance.

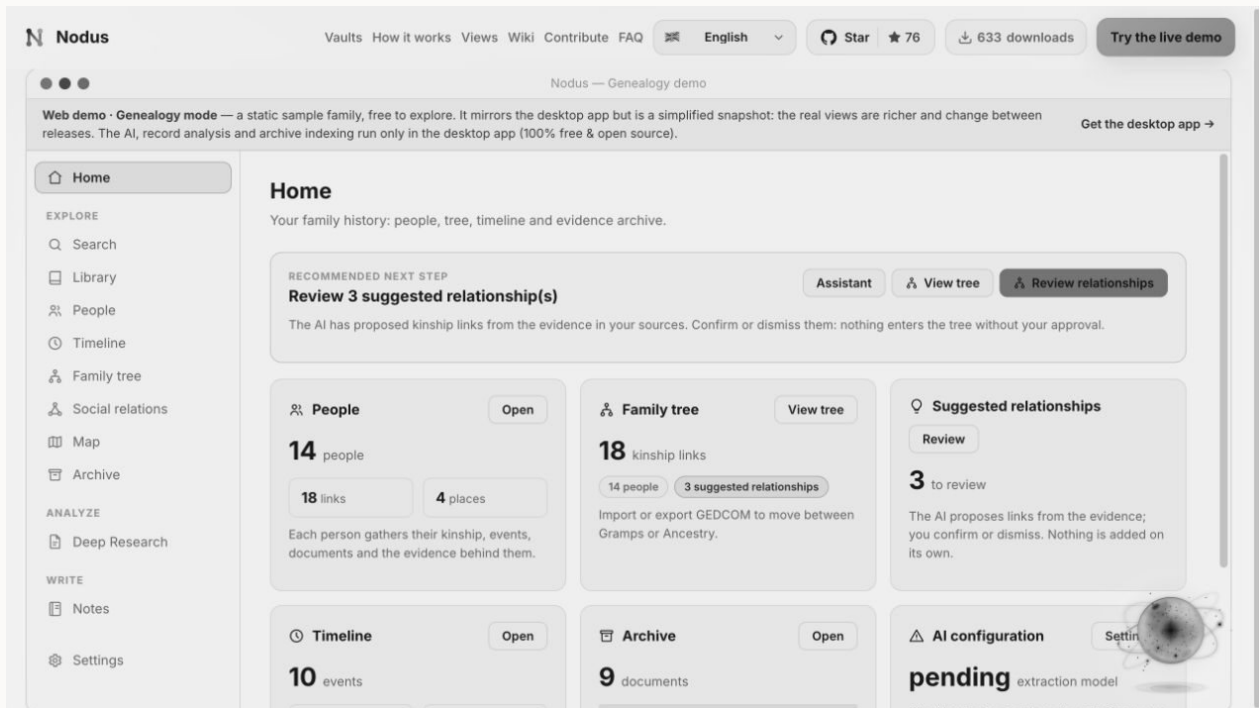
Home highlights recent work and unresolved relationship suggestions so that documentary review stays ahead of decorative tree building.

STEP BY STEP

1. Review vault totals and recent changes.
2. Open suggested relationships before expanding the tree.
3. Use the Archive or People shortcuts to continue evidence entry.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Record uncertain information explicitly instead of silently choosing one version.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

EXPLORE

2 Vault search

Search people, events and the full text of transcribed records from one box.

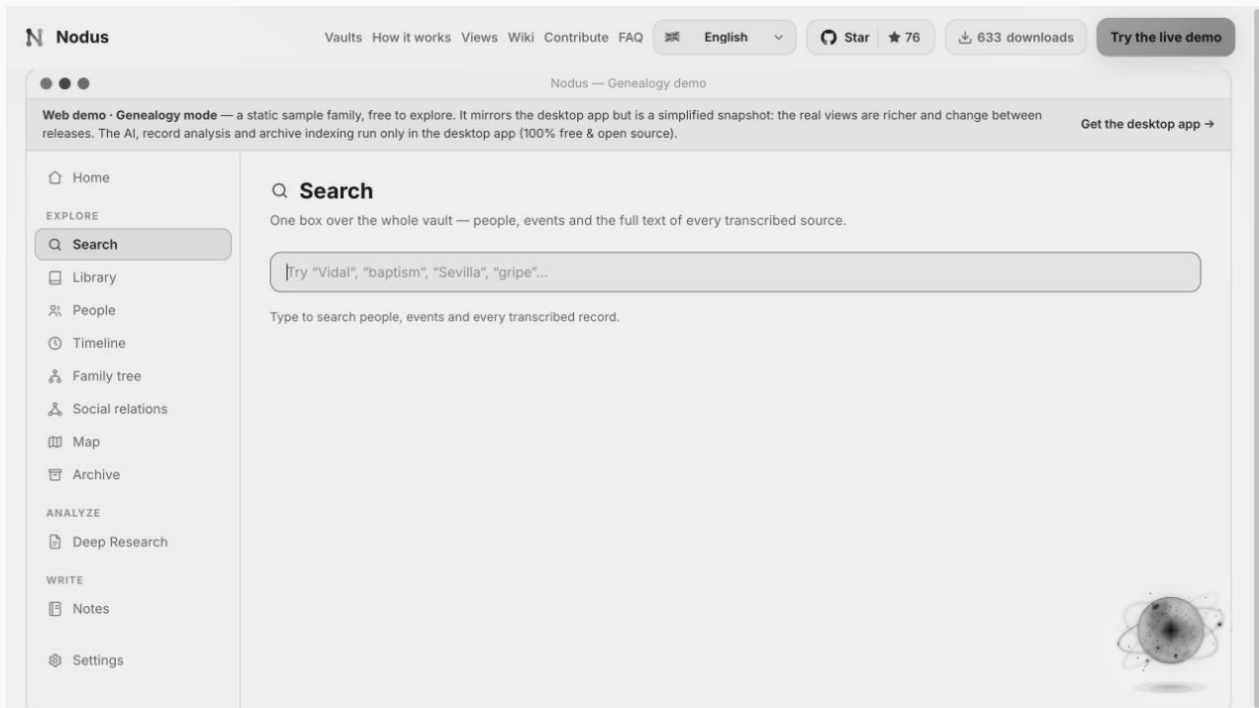
Search crosses structured names and dates as well as OCR or transcript text. Results open the corresponding person, event or record.

STEP BY STEP

1. Search a surname, place, occupation, date or phrase from a record.
2. Compare entity types and spelling variants.
3. Open the source result and confirm the transcription against the image.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Try historical spelling variants and nearby place names.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

EXPLORE

3 People and profiles

Create a documented profile with names, dates, places, identifiers and linked evidence.

A person profile is the hub for life events, relationships, records and notes. Unknown, approximate and disputed values should remain distinguishable.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a person with the minimum known identity fields.
2. Add life events with dates, places and citations rather than typing an unsupported biography.
3. Link records and relationships, then review duplicate or conflict warnings.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use alternate names for aliases, married names and spelling variants.

EXPLORE

4 Family tree

Navigate ancestors, descendants and partners through an evidence-led tree.

The tree visualises accepted relationships and lets you focus, pan and zoom. It is a navigation surface; the person profile and attached sources remain authoritative.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Family tree and select a focus person.
2. Expand the relevant generation or branch and inspect relationship markers.
3. Open a person card to verify parents, partners and children against evidence.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Resolve duplicate people before merging branches.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

EXPLORE

5 Timeline

Place personal and family events in chronological context.

The timeline brings births, marriages, residences, occupations, deaths and other events together. Filters help isolate one person, branch or period.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a date range or person filter.

2. Open an event to inspect date precision, place, participants and sources.
3. Add a note when chronology exposes an impossibility or ambiguity.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep 'about', 'before' and 'after' date precision instead of inventing exact dates.

EXPLORE

6 Social relations

Document witnesses, neighbours, employers and other non-kin connections.

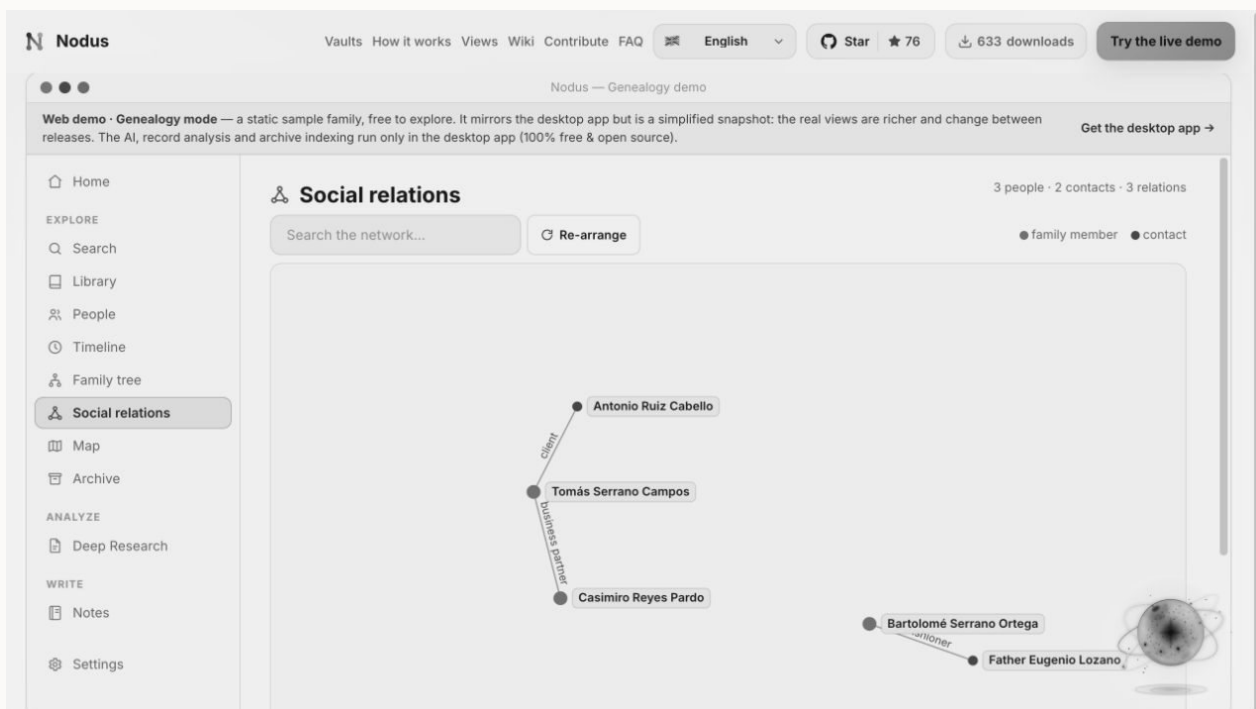
Genealogical evidence often travels through social networks. Typed relations preserve the role, period and documentary basis of each connection.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create or select both people.
2. Choose the relation type, direction and relevant dates.
3. Attach the record or note that supports the connection.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Do not turn every shared record into a permanent relationship; capture context and confidence.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

EXPLORE

7 Map

Explore residences, migrations and event locations spatially.

Places are shared structured entities rather than repeated free text. A map point opens the events and people connected to that location.

STEP BY STEP

1. Standardise a place name and coordinates.
2. Open Map and filter by person, branch or event type.
3. Follow a point to the underlying events and records.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Preserve the historical place label even when adding modern coordinates.

EXPLORE

8 Archive and records

Preserve certificates, censuses, letters and photographs with transcription, OCR and links.

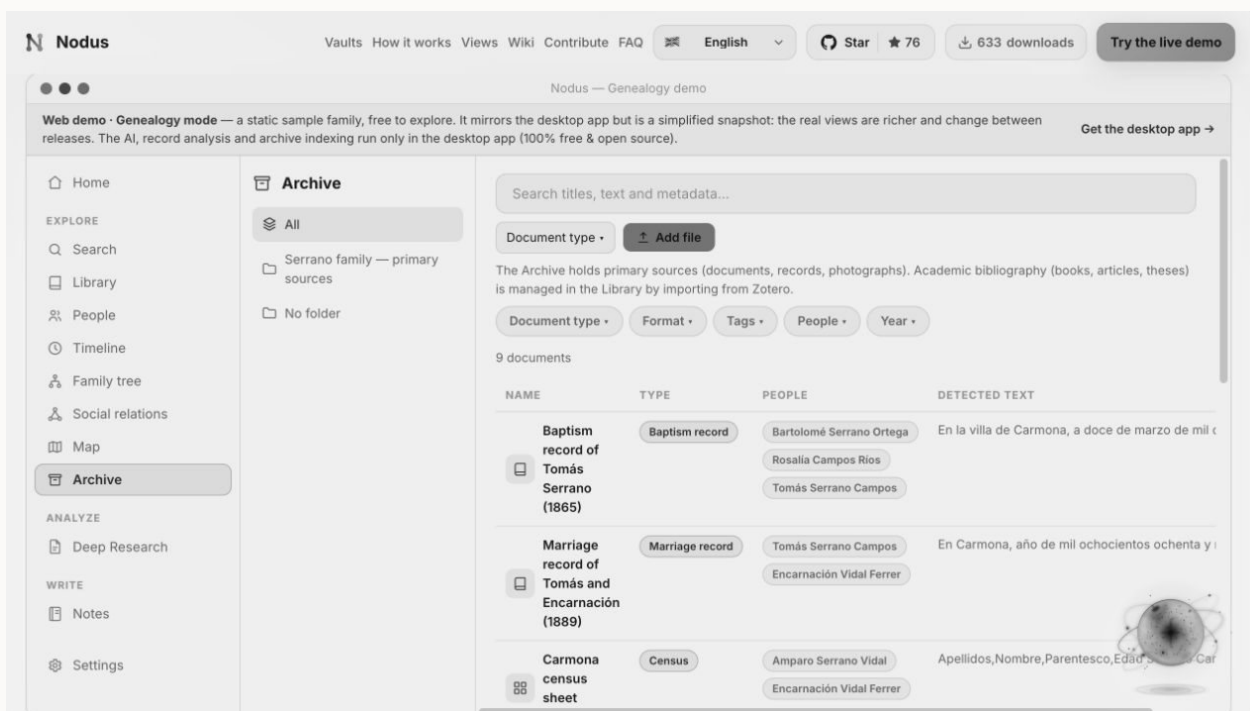
The Archive stores primary sources separately from secondary literature. Records can be grouped in folders, analysed for text and linked to people and events.

STEP BY STEP

1. Import a record and choose an appropriate document type and folder.
2. Review image orientation, OCR or transcription, metadata and source citation.
3. Link every identified person and event, marking uncertain identifications.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the unedited original image and record archive, collection and call-number provenance.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

EXPLORE

9 Secondary literature

Use the shared Library for histories and methods that frame the reconstruction.

Books and articles belong in Library while certificates and family photographs belong in Archive. Both can inform notes and reports without collapsing their evidential roles.

STEP BY STEP

1. Import relevant local histories or connect Zotero.
2. Link the source into the genealogy vault.
3. Highlight passages that clarify context, method or place history.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A published family tree is not automatically a primary source.

ANALYSE

10 Genealogy Deep Research

Synthesize a lineage or research question from structured records and notes.

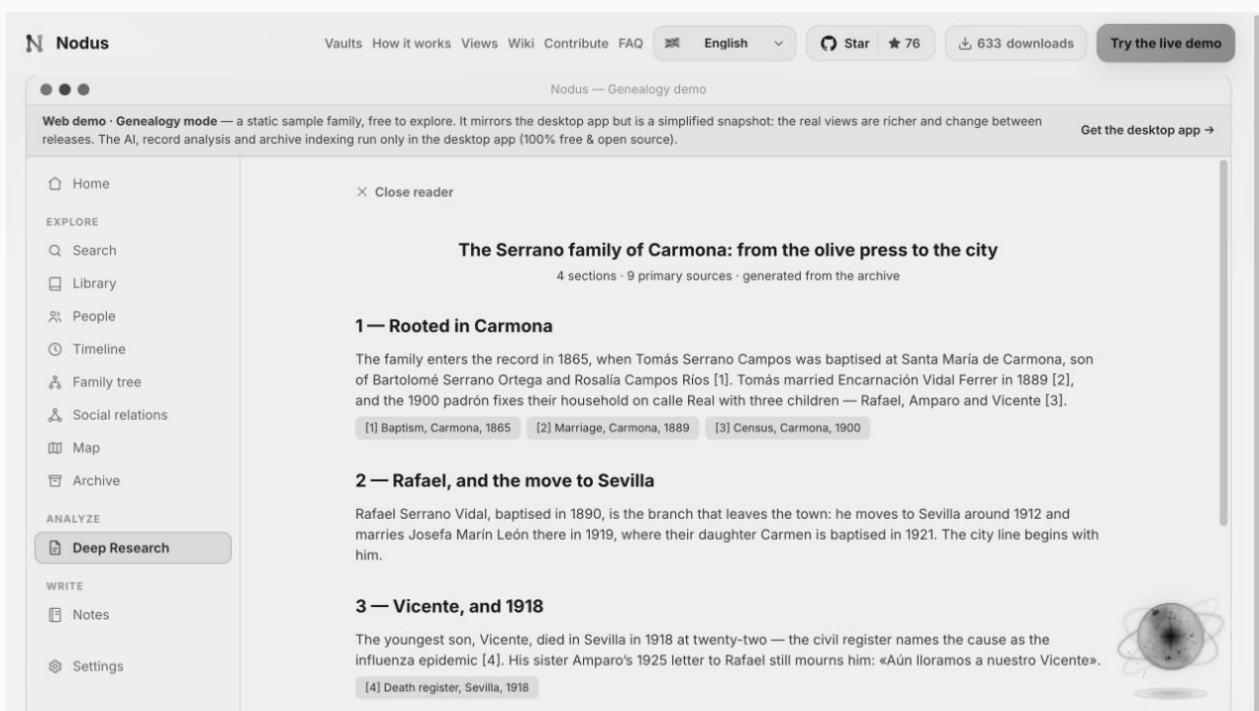
Reports can combine people, events, places, archival records and secondary literature while retaining citations and uncertainty language.

STEP BY STEP

1. Ask a bounded question about a person, branch, migration or conflict.
2. Choose the relevant scope and start the queued report.
3. Audit every relationship and date in the result against the cited record.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A report should preserve conflicting evidence rather than silently resolve it.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

WRITE

11 Research notes

Keep hypotheses, transcription decisions and next searches linked to the evidence.

Notes provide flexible space for reasoning that does not yet belong in a person or event record. Links prevent conclusions from becoming detached from their sources.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a note with a question-oriented title.

2. Link people, records and places mentioned in the note.
3. Separate observed facts, interpretations and next actions.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Maintain a research log for negative searches as well as discoveries.

EXCHANGE

12 GEDCOM import and export

Exchange structured family data while reviewing what the format cannot preserve.

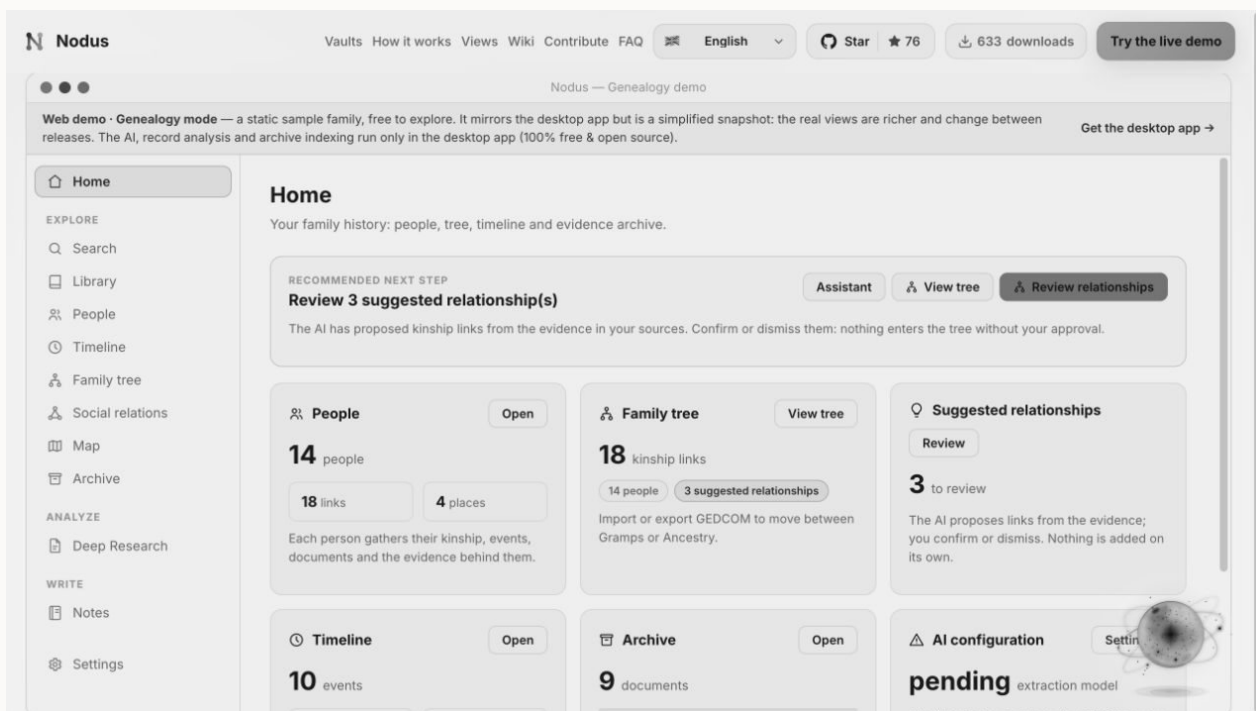
GEDCOM can seed or share people and family relations, but application-specific evidence, notes and media may not round-trip perfectly.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a backup, then preview a GEDCOM import and its duplicates or warnings.
2. Map or review people and relationships before committing.
3. After export, open the file in a second tool and verify names, dates and links.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Never treat GEDCOM transfer as a full archival backup.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

CONFIGURE

13 Genealogy settings

Configure OCR, Library, maps, models, integrations and backups.

Settings control extraction and optional analysis while keeping the genealogy database local.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose OCR and transcription defaults suitable for the records.
2. Review provider and model choices before analysing sensitive documents.
3. Enable automatic backups and verify a restore point.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Living-person data deserves stricter sharing and provider choices.

REFERENCE

Completion checklist

- The vault scope and name match the project.
- Sources or records have preserved originals and reviewed metadata.
- Generated interpretations have been checked against their evidence.
- Optional providers and integrations use only the intended data.
- Exports have been proofread in their final format.
- A recent backup has been created and verified.

This manual documents the stable English workflow represented in Nodus 4.1. Interface details may evolve between releases; the in-app privacy notice and release notes govern the exact behaviour of the installed version.